Rugged Individualism

Herbert Hoover · campaign speech · New York City · October 22, 1928 · excerpts

Source: Herbert Hoover, campaign address, New York City (Oct. 22, 1928), text via The American Presidency Project, UC Santa Barbara. Public domain.

Two weeks before he won the presidency, Hoover gave his major economic-philosophy speech at Madison Square Garden. He contrasted American 'rugged individualism' with what he saw as the European tradition of state paternalism. The speech aged badly: less than a year later the Great Depression began, and Hoover's reluctance to use federal power to address it became the central liability of his presidency.

Connect: Hoover's laissez-faire approach in 1929-33 was consistent with Republican philosophy since McKinley. What broke this consensus by 1932?

Key Passages

On American distinctiveness

When the war closed, the most vital of all issues both in our own country and throughout the world was whether governments should continue their wartime ownership and operation of many instrumentalities of production and distribution. We were challenged with a peacetime choice between the American system of rugged individualism and a European philosophy of diametrically opposed doctrines—doctrines of paternalism and state socialism. The acceptance of these ideas would have meant the destruction of self-government through centralization of government.

On equality of opportunity

The very essence of equality of opportunity and of American individualism is that there shall be no domination by any group or combination in this Republic, whether it be business or political. On the contrary, it demands economic justice as well as political and social justice. It is no system of laissez faire.

On government and business

We are nearer today to the ideal of the abolition of poverty and fear from the lives of men and women than ever before in any land. And I again repeat that the departure from our American system by injecting principles destructive to it which our opponents propose will jeopardize the very liberty and freedom of our people, will destroy equality of opportunity not alone to ourselves but to our children.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Prosperity of the 1920s under Republican presidents and laissez-faire policy; Hoover was running for president in 1928 against Democrat Al Smith.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Voters in the 1928 election; Republicans at Madison Square Garden and a national radio audience.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Herbert Hoover, a successful engineer, businessman, and commerce secretary who believed in voluntary cooperation and limited government.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Sourcing — HIPP for 3 docs (1 pt): Practice writing one sentence each of Historical situation, Intended audience, Purpose, and POV for Hoover's speech.
2. Identify ONE specific 1930s policy Hoover would have called 'state paternalism.'
3. How does this speech's framing of poverty differ from FDR's First Inaugural five years later?